

Cassandra Sawers – Artist Statement



The lights were dimmed, and the room was filled with the aroma of smudging herbs and the unmistakable sound of Indigenous drumming. Elders spoke to us as we sat in a circle, draping a beautiful Pendleton blanket over each of our shoulders. This was the setting of the blanket ceremony to commemorate my Indigenous graduation from the University of Calgary.

The significance of blankets in Indigenous culture can be interpreted in a number of ways. The blanket can be valued for its practicality while also being revered for its symbolic meaning. My kokum has taught me through oral history that the blanket, and partaking in a blanket ceremony, is a metaphorical cloak of growth and change. My kokum is a Cree Metis woman from the Kapawe'no Reserve located in Treaty 7 territory. Through these teachings, I view the blanket as a sign of progress and a way to celebrate a new beginning in one's life. As I am graduating this term and entering a new period of my legal career, these principles inspired me to create a knitted blanket for my final project in treaty litigation. Without the patient direction of my paternal kokum and my maternal grand-mère, this effort would not have been possible. They both met with me online throughout the semester to teach me about this craft. As a Metis woman, I considered these sessions to be incredibly sacred because I was learning valuable instruction from parallel sides of my family tree. The implicit undertone of these discussions was symbolic of the ties between two cultures that formed the Metis identity. The process of learning crochet was tedious and difficult at times, but it also provided opportunities for collaboration. This work transcended my law school learning from reading legal texts to performing kinetic actions to create a piece of work. Learning a new competence, like the legal skills we've been taught in this seminar, takes patience, time, and cooperation.

Throughout the course, I've learnt about the countless legal efforts of remarkable lawyers who collaborated with tenacious Indigenous communities to establish landmark legal precedents. Compassion, creativity, and teamwork were all prevalent themes amongst the speakers. These relationships seemed to go beyond the usual lawyer-client relationship, instead seeking to construct a more nuanced environment for Indigenous recognition inside the larger colonial legal

system. As I progress through my legal study, I reflect that I take the current position of Indigenous rights in this province for granted, given the fact that only 60 years ago, someone like me couldn't even become a lawyer without surrendering my status. Perhaps it was because of this knowledge that I felt a natural sense of pride as I learned about these numerous stories of legal craftsmanship.

When creating legal arguments with Indigenous communities, Louise Mandell spoke to our class about the need of thinking about law in terms of story and seeing beyond the written words of colonial law. This philosophy inspired me to design a blanket that represented the story of Indigenous rights in British Columbia. The blanket's colors were chosen with care to highlight how the blanket is reflective of the land and how Indigenous rights are inextricably linked to it. I saw the many communities cooperating to not only advance their own legal rights, but also to add their own square to the metaphorical blanket of Indigenous rights. Each piece on this patchwork blanket is designed to represent a case that has shaped the Indigenous rights framework. The blanket's structures also represent the imposition of colonial legislation, which seeks to put Indigenous rights into neat boxes, yet the concept cannot be regarded in isolation. These cases, too, cannot be regarded in isolation; they must be woven together to form the larger vision. Each crochet loop represents the different persons who have participated in these cases, including the communities, legal teams, and judicial bodies that make the decisions. I imagined these actors' emotional, intellectual, and spiritual efforts being braided together to form a broad framework for Indigenous rights. The blanket has a missing piece in the center that has been purposefully excluded. The exclusion is meant to symbolize that the status of Indigenous rights in Canada is far from complete, and that it will continue to be augmented by future Indigenous

cases. Creating this project has inspired me to envision the day that I may add my own stitch to the metaphorical blanket of Indigenous rights in this province.

Figure 1: My older sister and I at my Indigenous graduation in 2018.



Figure Two: The blanket representing the framework of Indigenous rights.

